TEACH IN FIVE MINUTES

read aloud - seven steps, then two short demonstrations

1. The goal (30 seconds)

"Diocletian has retired and the throne is empty. You will collect gear, win friends, and try to crown yourself. The claim your three rivals fail to stop inside two rounds wins the game."

2. Moving (30 seconds)

"On your turn, roll two dice and move up to the total along the white circles. Streets only - the hatched blocks are buildings. Stop anywhere. Then do one thing. That is a whole turn."

3. Equipment (45 seconds)

"The double circles A to F each hold one piece of gear - two start face up. Stop on one and mark it on your sheet. Each piece does one thing forever: the sword adds +1 to attacks, the shield +1 to defense, the javelin +1 against a claimant, the dagger wins ties, the helmet reveals a district once, the armor saves you once. In a duel you count your one best bonus - never a sum."

4. Prestige (60 seconds)

"This coin symbol is Prestige - political clout. Earn it at a star space: stop there, roll one die, 4 or higher pays 1. Win a duel: also 1. Lose a duel: pay 1 back to the bank. You can hold three. You will spend it on friends and on challenges."

5. Factions (45 seconds)

"Three groups can back you - the Army, the officials, the city elites. Their meeting places are marked on the SMALL map, the succession map: army east, officials west, elites north. Once the succession begins, walk to a meeting place and pay 1 Prestige - that faction supports you for the rest of the game. Get two different factions behind you. During the palace phase nobody can be bought."

6. The endgame (60 seconds)

"When someone holds all six items they claim at the crossing - the Peristyle - and the succession begins: one more round, then everyone moves to the small map, back at their own gate. The whole race for the throne happens there: buy support, stand at the Peristyle with two backers and proclaim. Your rivals now have two full rounds to stop you: move next to you, pay 1 Prestige, and duel. Win the duel and the claim dies. Nobody does it in time and you are emperor."

7. Start (15 seconds)

"Random gates, random start, start moves clockwise each round. Youngest player rolls first if you like. Let's play."

Two tiny demonstrations

Ordinary turn: roll 8, walk eight circles to a star, roll one die - a 5 - and take a Prestige. Done.

Claim response: a rival proclaims at the Peristyle. On your turn, move next to them, put 1 Prestige aside (the fee), then each roll one die and add your one best item bonus. Higher total wins; the pugio wins ties.

Answer everything else when it comes up. Rare cases live in the rulebook, not in the introduction.